



SARPANCHES AT A NATIONAL MEETING ON THE PANCHAYATI RAJ DIWAS ON APRIL 24, 2008

SIPRA DAS / ANA INDIAN IMAGES

|1993| THE 73RD CONSTITUTIONAL AMENDMENT It Takes a Village

But 16 years later, the Panchayati Raj system is still floundering

Mahatma Gandhi had first championed the idea of little village republics but it was under P.V. Narasimha Rao that the 73rd Constitutional Amendment Act, better known as the Panchayati Raj Act, became effective. As with all things Congress, the kudos for pushing this act goes to a member of the dynasty, Rajiv Gandhi. As former Panchayati Raj minister Mani Shankar Aiyar points out, there are three people who get credit for this. Mahatma Gandhi, Jawaharlal Nehru and Rajiv. In October 1989, Rajiv tried to pass the act in Parliament but the motion was defeated. For the general elections that followed, he had even toyed with the idea of kicking off his campaign from Nagaur in Rajasthan, where Nehru had set up India's first panchayat in 1959. And it was the Rajiv legacy rather than Rao's initiative that Aiyar marketed when he embarked on his famous four-day *padayatra* in 1993. Recalling it today, he says, "I remained faithful and was on foot for all four days." Apart from Aiyar, the other two leaders who nurtured the act through the joint committee stage were two MPs in the then Lok Sabha, Nitish Kumar and Digvijay Singh. Soon after it was notified in 1993, Singh won the Madhya Pradesh elections on this plank. Today there are 2.5 lakh panchayats in India. At Aiyar's initiative, the panchayats can now instruct the Planning Commission on what they need for their development, instead of the other way round. The system is also a great tool for social empowerment. With 33 per cent reservation, out of the 3.2 million elected representatives, 1.2 million are women. Of these, 80,000 are sarpanches. This year, the Union Cabinet has okayed 50 per cent reservation for women. But complaints of neglect by the Centre still persist. Mourns Aiyar, "After Rajiv, the political will has been lacking. Merely providing funds will not solve the problem of inclusive growth." Even 16 years after its notification, Panchayati Raj still remains an arena for argument.

ALSO

- Harshad Mehta accuses P.V. Narasimha Rao of corruption
- An earthquake in Latur, Maharashtra, leaves over 15,000 dead
- The Indian rupee is made fully convertible on current account

by Priya Sahgal

THE MAIN EVENT

Mumbai Bomb Blasts

For a metropolis that had barely recovered from the communal frenzy that took over 600 lives, the latest disaster came like a series of frenzied hammer blows. In the space of just over two-and-a-half hours on a Friday afternoon, international terrorism, in its most macabre and frightening form, rampaged through Bombay, shattering buildings and taking a deadly toll of human lives. Even the traditional targets of terrorist bombs—Lebanon, London, Germany in the late '70s, and New York earlier this month—have never been victim to this kind of sequential bombings on a single day and with such a massive body count. Two days after Black Friday, the tally of deaths had crossed 300 with 1,500 injured.

India Today, March 31, 1993



KFC (1996) The Karnataka Raita Sangha believed that KFC used genetically modified chicken with two heads.

T.A. Majeed (1997) Majeed feared that the allopathic lobby was out to kill him for developing a "cure" for AIDS.

Iodised Salt (2004) The Swadeshi Jagran Manch alleged it was a tool of MNCs to expose Indians to diseases.

Colgate (2004) Some RSS members claimed that the company channelled its profits to Christian missionaries.

Veerappan (2004) There is a rumour in the villages near Sathyamangalam Hills, Tamil Nadu, that he is still alive.